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EDITORIAL

Artificial Intelligence and Psychotherapy

Promises, limits, and the question of meaning

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ABSTRACT

Conversational systems based on large language models have rapidly entered everyday life, and many people now use them for support, advice, and conversations about personal difficulties. Psychotherapy research and practice therefore face the task of assessing these developments soberly, without either uncritical enthusiasm or blanket rejection. This editorial introduces a special issue of the Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology devoted to artificial intelligence and psychotherapy. It outlines the potential benefits that are currently discussed, such as wider access to support, help between sessions, and relief from administrative tasks, and it names the limits that remain, including a thin and short-term evidence base, uncertain safety in crisis situations, and erroneous output. The editorial then briefly presents the eleven contributions of the issue, which comprise narrative reviews, theoretical analyses, a methods paper, and practice-oriented articles on topics ranging from chatbots and prediction models to ethics, training, and clinical documentation. Finally, it formulates the guiding question of the issue from a logotherapeutic perspective: if meaning must be discovered by the person rather than supplied from outside, how can digital tools support this personal task without short-circuiting it, and what remains genuinely human in the therapeutic encounter?

Keywords: artificial intelligence · psychotherapy · large language models · logotherapy · meaning

Between promise and caution

When Joseph Weizenbaum presented ELIZA in the 1960s, he was struck by how readily people attributed understanding to a program that essentially reflected their own words back to them (Weizenbaum, 1966). Six decades later, systems based on large language models produce fluent, context-sensitive replies, and many people already turn to them for comfort, advice, and something that resembles a conversation about their lives. Psychotherapy can neither ignore this development nor simply welcome or reject it.

The promises are real. Digital interventions can reach people who would otherwise receive no help, can offer support between sessions, and can relieve clinicians of administrative burdens (Torous et al., 2021). The first randomized trial of a fully generative therapy chatbot reported greater symptom improvement than a waitlist condition (Heinz et al., 2025). At the same time, the field is young, the evidence base is thin, and the risks, from erroneous output to inadequate responses in crises, are not yet well understood. Calls for responsible development and staged evaluation are therefore timely (Stade et al., 2024).

In this issue

This issue brings together eleven contributions that approach the topic from empirical, methodological, ethical, and existential perspectives. A narrative review summarizes the evidence on conversational agents for mental health, from rule-based programs to systems built on large language models. Two theoretical papers ask whether a working alliance with a machine is conceivable and whether language models can support the Socratic dialogue through which logotherapy helps people discover meaning. A methods paper outlines how AI-based interventions should be evaluated and reported.

A second review examines machine learning for predicting treatment response, dropout, and suicide risk, with particular attention to base rates and clinical utility. Further contributions address ethics and regulation, the automated analysis of psychotherapy sessions by means of natural language processing, and

the use of simulated clients in the training of psychotherapists and counselors. A paper on AI companions discusses dependency, uncritical validation, and crisis handling, and a practice-oriented article offers recommendations for using AI tools in everyday clinical work. The issue closes with a reflection on what remains specifically human in psychotherapy.

The question of meaning

Psychotherapy research has long emphasized that outcomes depend substantially on relational factors such as the alliance, empathy, and the person of the therapist, not only on specific techniques (Wampold & Imel, 2015). This raises a question that technical evaluation alone cannot answer: what exactly happens when the counterpart in a conversation about suffering is a program?

From a meaning-centered perspective, the question becomes sharper still. Viktor Frankl understood the search for meaning as a personal task that cannot be delegated; meaning has to be found, it cannot be given (Frankl, 1985). A system that readily supplies interpretations may comfort, but it may also short-circuit the very process of discovering what a situation asks of a person. Conversely, carefully designed tools might stimulate reflection, structure self-observation, and lower the threshold for seeking human help.

The contributions in this issue do not resolve this tension, nor do they intend to. They aim to describe the current state of knowledge carefully, to name open questions precisely, and to keep the person, with their freedom and responsibility, at the center of the debate. We hope they will prove useful to researchers, clinicians, and students alike.

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